

SOUTHERN OCEAN ISLANDS

Inhospitable to man, last refuges for threatened species

Remote, mostly uninhabited volcanic islands, many with glaciers, ice caps, and snow fields year round, are dotted north of the 60 degrees south latitude line that marks the boundary of the Southern Ocean. They include South Georgia, South Sandwich, Bouvet, Prince Edward, and Kerguelen islands, and Heard Island. Situated close to the Antarctic Convergence, where cold Antarctic waters sink under warmer seas, these islands are home to a great variety and number of fish, birds, and mammals.

Lynchpin of the food chain

The food chain for the survival of all these creatures is based on tiny plankton and vast numbers of krill—small, shrimplike crustaceans. Krill form the staple diet of petrels and albatrosses, crabeater seals, and humpback, right, blue, fin, sei, and minke whales arriving from tropical seas for the Antarctic summer. Ironically,

whales were hunted from these islands until they were declared commercially extinct by 1965. This created a surplus of Antarctic krill, so other marine species subsequently increased. For example, fur seals, once thought extinct, now breed here in their millions. Yet even a krill surplus may not help slow-breeding whales. Human exploitation has now shifted to the krill itself, threatening the basis of all Antarctic sea life.

